REP-087 · Kickstarter art direction: audit, recommendation and pilot plan

Game	Fruit Market 1.7.0 (rules version 9). No game, app or print-kit change.
Report date	2026-11-07 (Asia/Kuala_Lumpur)
Type	Audit and recommendation. No images were generated and no assets were built.
Request	"Audit the existing Fruit Market art direction and character requirements. Recommend the strongest visual identity for a Kickstarter-first tabletop release with a subsequent mobile adaptation. Propose the first two characters to develop … and present a concrete production plan. Do not generate or implement assets yet."
Status	Awaiting the owner's approval: DEC-063 (art direction), PLAN-048 (pilot work package). The proposed direction is in `docs/art/ART_DIRECTION.md` (v0.1).

1. The short version

1. **Recommendation: a controlled hybrid, "Look E".** The world, frames and graphics take the crate-label style of "The Great Fruit Exchange". The people take the personality of "Orchard & Oddballs", but stay ordinary townsfolk. Everything is drawn in one flat screen-print style in the colours the game already uses.
2. **Three independent reviews agreed.** Each scored the options out of 45: hybrid 35 to 36, Oddballs alone 25 to 27, Exchange alone 22 to 25.
3. **The pixel look you like stays on the phone's board.** In the rule "the board shows tokens; cards show portraits", illustrated portraits go on printed cards, the box, the store and full-card views. Pixel people stay for the board, the queue and the wardrobe.
4. **Pilot characters: Benny (shopkeeper) and Sailor Jia Wen (customer).** They are the most different pair that is safe for hidden information, and between them they cover every place a character appears.
5. **Biggest commercial risk: AI art on Kickstarter.** Kickstarter allows it but requires public disclosure. Board-game backers react strongly, and UK Games Expo bans products made largely with AI. My advice is AI for ideas and drafts only, with every final picture finished by a person.
6. **Biggest game risk: art giving away secrets.** A customer's freshness type is fixed by who they are, so a face, a back or an edge colour that varies by customer would reveal it. ART_DIRECTION.md §9 sets hard rules against this.
7. **Fix before anything is printed:** the Drive print kit is still rules version 8, and two lists disagree between RULES.md and the game (generous customers, guest orders).
8. **Cost:** nothing is spent without a quote and your approval. A human artist for all 45 characters is estimated at USD 6,700 to 16,000, far above the RM500-a-month ceiling. The pilot is the cheap way to get real prices.

2. What was audited

- **Repo:** art code (`src/ui/pixel.tsx`, `propsArt.tsx`, `art.tsx`, `wearArt.ts`, `looks.ts`, `palette.ts`), the style guide, the creative bible, RULES.md, `src/engine/data.ts`, the online server's hidden-information code, tests and the print script.
- **Records:** every art, cast, look and print decision (DEC-014 to DEC-062) and reports REP-010 to REP-086.
- **Google Drive (read only):** the Print_Kit folder (51-page home-print PDF), Look_Comparison, Board_Look_Options, Cast_Coherence_Audit, and the Concept and Studio Lifecycle Companions.
- **Outside research:** Kickstarter's AI policy, backer and convention reactions, copyright of AI images (US, UK, EU, Malaysia), image-tool terms, factory print specifications, tool features and illustrator prices.
- **Method:** six parallel audits, then three independent judges (tabletop publisher, art-production lead, game identity), then my own checks of the key claims against the code.

3. What exists today

- **All art is drawn in code.** Fruit, icons, props and 50 people are text grids turned into small pictures. Portraits are 16 × 16 pixels from one shared face, told apart by hair, accessory, skin and shirt (DEC-041). There are no image files to replace.
- **Swapping art is clean.** Every screen asks for a portrait through one function (`Face` in `src/ui/art.tsx`), and names, quirks, perks and freshness types live separately in `data.ts`. A new portrait source would need no change to rules, saves or online play.
- **The 25 collectible looks** are 11 wearables drawn as pixel rows on the 16 × 16 face, plus 14 stall pieces. Wearables only work on the pixel face, which is why Look E keeps them there.
- **Print is thin and partly outside the repo.** Only the card-back script is in the repo (63 × 88 mm, no bleed, no crop marks, RGB). Customer, shopkeeper, mat and token pages were generated elsewhere. They are rules version 8 and lack the freshness type.
- **Printed portraits are small:** about 21 mm (customers) and 26 mm (shopkeepers), drawn from 16 × 16 pixels. They are the weakest asset for a polished Kickstarter box.
- **Your recorded taste:** you chose a smooth toy-box look (DEC-021, "go with plan b"), then moved back to pixel art twice (DEC-023, DEC-033 "Look C"), and praised the current look ("artstyle is awesome i love it", DEC-057). That is why Look E keeps pixel art on the board and shows every new design beside today's look before anything is built (DEC-042).
- **Precedent for AI art:** the lorry picture was made with Gemini, and you accepted that AI-made art may not be protected by copyright (history, PLAN-011). It was later replaced by pixel art for consistency (DEC-052).

4. The two directions, scored

Each judge scored nine criteria from 1 to 5: Kickstarter appeal, originality and IP safety, fit with the world, distinctiveness across 45 characters, AI consistency, print readability, phone readability, cost for a solo developer, and stereotype risk.

	Exchange alone	Oddballs alone	Hybrid
Tabletop publisher	23	27	36
Art-production lead	25	25	36

	Exchange alone	Oddballs alone	Hybrid
Game identity	22	27	35

- **The Great Fruit Exchange alone:** strong shelf appeal and a perfect match for lorries, events and the box. But many historic crate labels and fruit ads drew people as racist or "exotic" caricatures, and copying real labels risks copyright and trademark claims (Sunkist and Chiquita marks are still active). Detailed litho texture also blurs at phone sizes.
- **Orchard & Oddballs alone:** good personality and social energy. But "charming imperfection" is what AI tools keep least consistent, it slides toward exaggerated faces (against DEC-018 and DEC-041), and without a strong graphic frame it looks like generic mobile-game art.
- **Hybrid:** the Exchange supplies the graphics, built as templates with no AI, so every frame is identical and human-made. Oddballs supplies the attitude, expressed only through pose, prop and expression. One flat style ties them together. Its one weakness is that each person has two renderings, and a shared character spec keeps them in step.

5. The recommendation

Look E, as written in `docs/art/ART_DIRECTION.md`: principles, colour, type, proportions, line and texture, card layouts, print sizes, hidden-information rules, AI consistency rules and a banned list. It keeps the harbour world (DEC-017), the townsfolk cast (DEC-039 to DEC-041), the palette and the fonts. It adds one bold display face for titles, after a separate approval.

6. Pilot characters

Recommended: Benny (shopkeeper, Big Basket) + Sailor Jia Wen (customer, card 25).

	Benny	Sailor Jia Wen
Role	Shopkeeper; public perk; computer rival in the daily market	Everyday customer; wants 2 apples (top $6) and 2 mangoes (top $10)
Shape	Broad, round, bearded, steady	Slim, upright, quick
Colour	Warm brown shirt, skin tone c	Harbour navy, skin tone a
Head	Short dark hair and beard (a clean base for hats later)	Long black hair; the bible will propose a sailor's cap as her one accessory
Prop	The big basket (his perk is public, so showing it is fine)	A rolled "mango map" (her quirk), not coins, so no money cue

- **Why Benny:** a shopkeeper appears everywhere: player card, box, Kickstarter page, app avatar, home screen and wardrobe. His broad build tests the bust template. His perk gives a natural prop, and his simple head makes the cleanest anchor for wearable looks later.
- **Why Jia Wen:** she carries the identity of "a harbour where the whole world comes to shop". She is the honest hidden-information test: her back (apples and mangoes) is shared with two Premium cards, one Bargain card and one Everyday card. So any type hint in her art would be a pure leak, and the pilot proves there is none. She is Everyday and not generous in either list.
- **Contrast:** man and woman, broad and slim, warm and cool colours, bare head and cap, a shopkeeper's hero card and a small customer window.

- **Assumption:** Jia Wen is drawn as a young woman (her sprite has long hair). Say if you see her differently.
- **Runners-up:** Rosa + Grandpa Tan (Rosa's bun and glasses are the hardest test for hats and the monocle; Tan is the creative bible's sample character). Raj + Grandpa Tan (the deepest skin tone tests printing and small sizes).
- **Not a pilot yet:** Rara Jenab. She is your own approved design and a strong campaign face, but as a Premium card her back is already unique (section 11, item 4).

7. Production plan

Each stage ends with a stop for your approval. Nothing visual is built before you approve its design (DEC-042).

Stage	What happens	Output	Gate
0 (now)	Audit and direction	This report, ART_DIRECTION.md v0.1	You approve Look E and PLAN-048 and answer three questions
1	Character Bible	One line for all 45 characters plus the walk-in figure (build, shape, hair, prop, colours, type-cue check, fixes needed), full entries and master prompts for Benny and Jia Wen, style-lock sheet layout	You approve
2	Card templates (no AI)	Rules-9 customer, guest and shopkeeper fronts filled from `data.ts` , with bleed, crop marks and an empty portrait window, as home-print sheets and one-card-per-page factory PDFs; tested with the densest card	Built inside PLAN-048; shown to you
3	Pilot concepts	Three concept directions per pilot, scored on silhouette, personality, appeal and card readability, with a recommendation	You pick one per pilot
4	Pilot masters	Master reference, front, three-quarter and side views, six expressions, a person's clean-up pass, script checks, manifest entries, and a mock-up of the refreshed pixel token	Quote approved before any paid work
5	QA and style lock	Eight scores per character, each at least 4/5; printed at 100% on the template; phone mock-up next to today's look	You approve the style lock
6	Waves	Five more shopkeepers (Rosa first), then customers in waves of 6 to 8, guests and the Health Inspector	Each wave approved
7	Commercial readiness	Box key art, factory quote and spec, printed proof, provenance and licence review, Kickstarter "Use of AI" text, font credits, name and logo trademark check	Separate approvals; spending needs a quote
8	Phone adoption	Card views show portraits; pixel tokens refreshed; tests; performance budget; old saves keep loading	A separate plan

Images in this session: no image-generation tool is available here. For stage 3 I will prepare complete prompts and specifications for an outside tool. You (or I, in a session with a tool) make the images. I will not describe images I have not received.

QA scores (stage 5): identity consistency, distinctiveness, visual appeal, personality, tabletop readability, phone readability, style consistency and production readiness, each 1 to 5, all at least 4. Automatic flags: anatomy errors, clothing or face changes between views, unclear silhouette at 44 px, details that only read when zoomed, any text, symbol or type cue.

8. Asset structure (proposal; created at stage 4)

Where	What
`docs/art/`	ART_DIRECTION.md, CHARACTER_BIBLE.md, STYLE_LOCK.md
`art/manifest.json`	One row per asset version: ID (the existing character key, never renamed), use, tool, model version, date, terms checked, references, prompt, human changes, QA scores, approval
`art/prompts/`	Prompt and settings per character
`art/templates/`	Card frames and backs (SVG or HTML)
`scripts/print-cards.cjs`	Builds print PDFs from templates, game data and portraits (the existing Playwright route)
Drive `Fruit Market/Art_Masters/<id>/v001/`	Accepted raw images, layered source, cleaned transparent master (2048 px or larger), turnarounds, expression sheet. Never overwritten: a change makes v002.
Generated, never hand-made	Print PDFs (CMYK, with bleed), phone images (WebP at 1x, 2x and 3x), Kickstarter images

Large masters live on Drive rather than in git, so the repo, the Android build and the one-file web build stay small. Game data, words, prices, symbols and frames stay separate from the pictures, so a rule change never means redrawing art.

9. AI, copyright and Kickstarter

- **Kickstarter** allows AI content but requires a public "Use of AI" section: which tools, which parts are AI, which are original, and whether the source works had consent. Hiding AI use can get a project suspended.
- **Backers:** board-game buyers are among the most hostile audiences. Recent examples: review-bombing of an AI cover on BoardGameGeek (March 2026), UK Games Expo banning products made "completely or in significant part" with AI (September 2026), BackerKit barring content made only by AI, and award and publisher bans. One study of 63,829 campaigns links AI disclosure to about 40% lower funding. It is observational and covers all categories, not only board games.
- **Copyright:** in the US, prompts alone do not make you the author (Copyright Office, January 2025; Thaler lost, review refused March 2026). Human changes, and the selection and arrangement of material, can be protected. The UK may remove its computer-generated-works rule. Malaysia's Copyright Act 1987 has no AI provision and no court cases yet, and a consultation ran in 2026. Raw AI images may give no exclusive rights, so copycats could reuse them.
- **Tool terms:** most tools give you whatever rights exist in the output. Only paid business or API plans (Adobe enterprise, OpenAI business and API, Google Vertex) offer protection against

infringement claims. Midjourney offers none found, is being sued by major studios, and shows lower-tier images in a public gallery. Not recommended for shipped art.
- **Recommended policy:** AI for ideas and drafts. A person finishes every final character. A named, credited artist for the box and key art if the budget allows. Frames and graphics made by us in code. A manifest for every asset. An honest one-line disclosure.

10. Costs (estimates only; no quotes yet)

Item	Estimate	Source
Image tool	about USD 10 to 50 a month (consumer plans), or about USD 0.03 to 0.24 per image through an API	Vendor pages via search summaries
A person's clean-up per character	about USD 50 to 150	Production review estimate, unquoted
Full illustration per card	about USD 100 to 800	LaunchBoom, Stonemaier, Pine Island guides
Box cover	about USD 1,000 to 6,000	Same
All 45 characters by a human illustrator	about USD 6,700 to 16,000	Arithmetic from the above
Pilot (two characters)	one month of one tool plus a clean-up quote	To be quoted before any spend

The RM500-a-month ceiling (DEC-005) covers all games. A Kickstarter art budget would be a separate, one-off decision. The Studio Lifecycle Companion on Drive also recommends a separate launch budget. Nothing is spent until you approve a dated quote.

11. Problems found on the way (not art; for later)

1. **Generous customers disagree:** RULES.md lists 12 (including John, Grace and Lakshmi). The game computes 13 (including Daniel, Siti, Anna and Marcus). Checked by recomputing from `data.ts`.
2. **Guest orders disagree:** RULES.md says Influencer 3 mangoes at $11, Gym Club 4 blueberries, Hotel Chef 3/2/2. The game has 2 at $12, 3 at $8 and 2/1/1, all fixed.
3. **The Drive print kit is rules version 8:** no freshness type, the old "Not so" wording, old prices.
4. **Card backs list fruits in the card's own order,** which makes 9 cards unique from the back, including Premium Rara Jenab. A fixed fruit order would leave 4. (Separately, the fruit set alone already settles the type for 19 of 36 cards. That is how the rules work and is not changed here.)
5. **The online leak check** does not test that the freshness type is hidden on face-down walk-ins. Only the server's allow-list protects it today.
6. **The face-down "shopper" face** looks like Benny (same short hair and brown shirt).
7. **Likely bug (read in code, not reproduced):** online, any favour card a rival plays is announced as "Priority!" (`src/ui/game/animator.tsx` with the server's hidden-favour placeholder).
8. **Cast leftovers:** a fox sprite, 13 unused creature and costume parts, "animal traders" comments in `data.ts`, the creative bible's identity line still listing vampires and mermaids (DEC-039 removed creatures), and 11 sprites with two accessories against the one-accessory rule.

9. **Misleading quirks:** Bargain Wei Jie inspects fruit with a magnifier, Bargain Mei Ling splashes sellers of soggy fruit, Everyday Zul "wants fresh fruit".
10. **Store, launcher and splash art** use an older, off-palette style. No font licence or credit file exists.
11. **STATE.md was out of date** (it said 1.2.0 was live; the release records say 1.7.0 was published on 2026-11-07). Its top section is updated in this commit.

12. Evidence quality and limits

- **Repo claims** were checked against the code. The generous list, guest orders, back uniqueness, walk-in redaction and the leak check were re-run or re-read by hand.
- **Outside figures** come from web search summaries. Fetching primary pages was blocked in this session, so Kickstarter, tool and factory wording must be re-checked on their own pages, with dates, before any decision that depends on them. Prices change often.
- **NOT RUN:** a physical print test; any image generation; a factory quote; a legal opinion on Malaysian copyright; a trademark search.
- **Not applicable:** game tests. No game code, rules or data were changed.

13. Questions for you

1. **AI and budget:** should final character art be AI drafts finished by a paid, credited artist (recommended), or AI finals finished by us with public disclosure? May I collect quotes for a one-off art budget outside RM500 a month? Nothing is spent until you approve a quote.
2. **Phone game:** keep the pixel people on the board and in the wardrobe, with illustrated portraits only on cards, box, store and full-card views (recommended)? Or replace the pixel people everywhere, which also means redrawing the 25 looks?
3. **Pilots:** Benny + Sailor Jia Wen (recommended), Rosa + Grandpa Tan, or Raj + Grandpa Tan?

Assumptions unless you say otherwise: Kickstarter means a factory-made box (open since REP-038). The product name stays *Fruit Market*. The text mismatches in section 11 are settled before anything is printed, not before concept work.